ence he calls his "film school". Kumar then set out to write his first feature and later pitched a show to MTV. When both projects failed to take off, Kumar turned to online video, his last resort. He banked on the prediction one of his IIT professors made back in 2004 when YouTube wasn't even around—"videos on internet will be a common thing". Along with Biswapati Sarkar, a graduate from IIT Kharagpur, and Amit Golani from IIT Bombay, he created *Inglorious Seniors*, a satirical take on ragging, and put it up in 2011. TVF was officially born on February 22, 2012 with a spoof of *Roadies* called *Rowdies 9*. The channel's tagline read "India's first online TV for youth". Fellow IITians Biswapati Sarkar, Amit Golani, Deepak Kumar Mishra, and non-IITians Anandeshwar Dwivedi and Nidhi Bisht were part of the core team.

It didn't take the bunch too long to make their presence felt. In October 2014, TVF presented its first web series, *Permanent Roommates*, also India's first. It created quite a splash when it bucked industry trends and had an episode that was 50 minutes long. The next year came another hit series in *Pitchers* and the YouTube channel had a million subscribers. The company also became experts at integrating brands into its work—it partnered with real estate portal Commonfloor for *Permanent Roommates*, *Pitchers* was presented by Kingfisher and *Tripling* featured Tata Motors' Tiago. By January 2016, the company had raised $10 million through the New York-based investment firm Tiger Global Management, which would later invest another $11 million. In late 2018, TVF, after sharing all its content freely on YouTube and TVFPlay, made its first feature for an SVOD (subscriber video-on-demand platform)—*Gullak* for SonyLiv. Gajraj Rao, whose popularity soared after he was cast as "dad" in TVF sketches, says "just like how Ekta Kapoor made a wave on television and changed its grammar, Arunabh and his army have done so online. In fact, they did not change, they *built* the grammar of how online content should be made."

THE PRICE OF BEING METICULOUS

Few companies can boast of having multiple shows that have sustained themselves over multiple seasons. Shreyansh Pandey, head of TVF Originals, attributes their success to the time invested in writing. A graduate of mining engineering from IIT Kharagpur, he refers to his job as "content mining". At least a year is devoted to develop and write the first season. In some cases like *Panchayat*, it took three and a half years, while *Aspirants* took two years. Rao calls it one of the few production companies that accord the highest respect to the writers. "For us, writing is not an individualistic process. We sit down with writers," says Pandey. "You have to get the fundamentals right, only then can you think ahead."

It's noteworthy that TVF operates with a product-driven mentality rather than

Famous Five

PERMANENT ROOMMATES [YOUTUBE, 2014-]

TVF struck gold with its very first series, also India's first web series, which follows a young couple in a live-in relationship through their many highs and lows



PITCHERS [YOUTUBE, 2015-]

A show about four guys who quit their jobs to set up their own start-up made Naveen Kasturia and Jitendra Kumar campus stars



KOTA FACTORY [YOUTUBE, NETFLIX, 2019-]

Shot in black-and-white, *Kota Factory* beautifully captures the zeitgeist of teenagers trying to crack the IIT-JEE in the city famed for its coaching classes





GULLAK [SONYLIV, 2019-]

This portrait of a middle-class family is equal parts delightful, affecting and convincing thanks to its detailed writing and fine ensemble of actors

PANCHAYAT [PRIME VIDEO, 2020-]

An engineering grad reluctantly takes up a job as a panchayat secretary to find himself drawn to its large-hearted inhabitants. A brilliant sketch of village life.

